



CONGRESS CHIEF BALMUCHU (LEFT) AND PARTNER MARANDI MAY NOT BE ABLE TO COBBLE UP NUMBERS

considering that Team Saffron had won as many as eight of the 14 Lok Sabha seats in the May general elections, which were held when the state was under President's Rule. Then, everyone thought the BJP would just run away with the trophy during the Assembly polls. Clearly, here is some food for thought for Nitin Gadkari, the new party president.

More importantly, the electorate has refused to see any of the coalitions as a credible political force. The results are an expression of the electorate's frustration at the political experiments the state has been subjected to, so far. Despite having seen troubles of coalition politics, it has once again allowed micro factors to influence their voting pattern. This is a reaffirmation that

Jharkhand is yet to have a leader with a state-wide following or credibility.

In the Lok Sabha elections just seven months ago, the JMM and Congress were routed and the BJP emerged triumphant. The tables have now turned. There have been some interesting results. Though many big names have lost, the victory of Koda's wife Geeta Koda and that of former cabinet ministers, Enosh Ekka and Harinarayan Rai—who are currently in jail after being charge-sheeted in disproportionate assets cases—suggests that corruption has ceased to be an issue.

Jharkhand was created as the 28th State of the Union along with Chhattisgarh and Uttarakhand in November 2000. The state, which ironically, was the richest in terms of min-

eral wealth and progress potential, was expected to sprint ahead with a sense of purpose. Nine years later, the script appears to have gone horribly wrong. The state has so far been governed from the bottom up, ministry by ministry, and district by district because of compelling alliances and independents calling the shots.

INDIA TODAY's State of the States Survey 2009 suggested as much with Jharkhand finishing at number 19th—just above Bihar—in overall ranking among 20 big states. It has been there all of last six years. While several studies have shown that Uttarakhand and Chhattisgarh, the two other states that came into being in the same month as Jharkhand, have moved up the ladder, Jharkhand continues to bring up the rear across the many parameters. In 2009, the state manned the bottom space in Agriculture and Infrastructure, 15th in Macro Economy, Law and Order and Consumer Market, 16th position in Primary Health, 18th in Primary Education, and 12th in Investment Environment. The good news is that the state still clocked 7.96 per cent of the GDP growth, which was higher than the national average of 7.8 per cent.

What ails Jharkhand? Simply put, the state has failed to utilise its strengths, namely the mineral wealth, which allowed its weaknesses to grow bigger and weakened its economy.

And the reasons? Absence of stability is surely one huge determinant, as Jharkhand has seldom been under stable, long-term management. Evidently, the loss of all frontline parties accentuates their lack of credibility. In hindsight, observers are apprehensive that the results may be a sign of stagnation of political growth in the state. However, the realpolitik message in the so-called rejection of the frontline parties may force them to be more accommodative to stitch a government. While both the Congress and BJP are capable of doing it, the possibility has a definitive undertone to it, which says that the party in the government may start looking for and activate other options if pushed too much. Seems the latest Jharkhand story has been scripted by the devil himself. ■

The state has been a laggard in various national parameters

INFRASTRUCTURE	MACRO ECONOMY	CONSUMER MARKETS	LAW AND ORDER
20th	15th	15th	15th